AMERICAN PSYCHOLOGICAL ASSOCIATION

Emotion

ISSN: 1528-3542

2026, Vol. 26, No. 2, 513–518
https://doi.org/10.1037/emo0001547

BRIEF REPORT

The Link Between Need Frustration and Empathic Accuracy in Romantic Relationships

Aurelia Lilly Scharmer[1], Lara Stas[1], William Ickes[2], and Lesley Verhofstadt[1]
[1] Department of Experimental-Clinical and Health Psychology, Ghent University
[2] Department of Psychology, University of Texas at Arlington

The frustration of relational needs is a common source of conflict in romantic relationships. Empathic accuracy (EA) defined as the ability to accurately perceive and understand a partner's thoughts and feelings plays a key role in resolving these conflicts. In this study, we tested the hypothesis that need frustration and EA are associated both within individuals and between romantic partners during actual conflict interactions. Data were analyzed from a lab-based conflict interaction study conducted in 2014, which included a video-mediated recall task. Results from two cross-sectional actor–partner interdependence models revealed that women's EA was positively associated with their male partner's need frustration at the start of the conflict, but this association was no longer present by the end. Additionally, women's EA was marginally negatively associated with their own need frustration at both the start and end of the conflict interaction. These findings highlight the complex and dynamic nature of the relationship of need frustration and EA during couples' actual conflict interactions. Further research is needed to explore the underlying mechanisms driving these associations over time.

Keywords: empathic accuracy, need frustration, romantic relationships, actor–partner interdependence model

Supplemental materials: https://doi.org/10.1037/emo0001547.supp

Autonomy, relatedness, and competence are fundamental relational needs that are important in romantic relationships (self-determination theory; Ryan & Deci, 2000). When these relational needs get frustrated, for example through the high interdependence of romantic partners, partners might feel a lack of control over their decisions and actions (autonomy frustration), a sense of disconnection and feeling uncared for by one's partner (relatedness frustration), or incapable of meeting their relationship goals (competence frustration). Previous research showed that this kind of need frustration during daily life can contribute to relationship conflict, manifesting in higher conflict frequency, less constructive conflict behavior and communication patterns (Patrick et al., 2007; Vanhee et al., 2016, Vanhee et al., 2018), and lower levels of relationship satisfaction (Patrick et al., 2007; Vanhee et al., 2016). However, previous research examined need frustration at a general level within the relationship, where partners' responses likely involve broad considerations of the general state of the relationship. This level of analysis can be clearly differentiated from that which applies to specific interactions and might overlook the nuance of context-specific, possibly dyadic, effects. By examining need frustration within the context of actual couple conflicts, we can gain more precise insights into how it influences or is influenced by romantic partners dynamics during these interactions.

Empathic accuracy (EA; Ickes, 1993, p. 588)—the ability to accurately perceive and understand a partner's thoughts and feelings—can play a critical role in managing and resolving conflicts (Lazarus et al., 2018). Research has demonstrated that higher levels of EA are associated with positive relationship outcomes, including enhanced prosocial behavior (Eckland et al., 2020; Kilpatrick et al., 2002) and overall relationship satisfaction (Sened et al., 2017). Given the importance of EA for constructive conflict resolution and the need to gain a better understanding of couples' conflict dynamics, it is important to explore the potential association between need frustration—one of the drivers of couples' conflict—and EA during couples' actual conflict interactions. Although previous research

This article was published Online First June 2, 2025.
Amie M. Gordon served as action editor.
Aurelia Lilly Scharmer https://orcid.org/0000-0002-1980-5103
The data are available at https://osf.io/xt58w/. This research was funded by the Fonds Wetenschappelijk Onderzoek awarded to Lesley Verhofstadt (Grant 11Q9516N) and Lara Stas (Grant S002719N) and the Interuniversitaire Bijzonder Onderzoeksfonds awarded to Lesley Verhofstadt (Grant 01IB2920).

Aurelia Lilly Scharmer played a lead role in conceptualization, data curation, and writing–original draft, a supporting role in visualization, and an equal role in formal analysis. Lara Stas played a lead role in software, a supporting role in writing–review and editing, and an equal role in formal analysis. William Ickes played an equal role in conceptualization and writing–review and editing. Lesley Verhofstadt played a lead role in funding acquisition, project administration, supervision, and writing–review and editing and an equal role in conceptualization.

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Aurelia Lilly Scharmer, Department of Experimental-Clinical and Health Psychology, Ghent University, Henri Dunantlaan 2, 9000 Ghent, Belgium. Email: aurelialilly.scharmer@ugent.be

suggests a link between need frustration and EA during couples' conflict, this association has yet to be empirically investigated.

Research shows that EA reflects the perceiver's current motivation. For example, EA may increase when people are motivated by factors such as monetary incentives (Klein & Hodges, 2001) or the desire to understand a partner's distress (Verhofstadt et al., 2016). In the context of couple conflict, one partner's need frustration might motivate the other to dial up their EA in an effort to better understand their partner's distress and reach conflict resolution.

The notion that need frustration can serve as an interpersonal motivator aligns with functional accounts of emotions, which posit that emotions serve the interpersonal function to help individuals communicate and pursue their needs (Keltner & Haidt, 1999; Van Kleef, 2009). In the context of couple conflict, one partner's experience of need frustration might act as a signal, prompting the other partner to recognize unmet needs and motivating them to dial up their EA in order to better understand and fulfill those needs. Given that women often take a more active role in conflict management (Hojjat, 2000), it is possible that this association might differ by gender, with women possibly being more active in trying to understand their partners' feelings and thoughts during conflict. Although these findings suggest a positive association between need frustration and EA between partners, the reverse causal relationship is also plausible. Partners with higher levels of EA may be more adept at identifying and meeting their partner's needs, which could reduce the likelihood of need frustration arising in the first place, pointing to a negative association between partners.

In addition to these interpersonal dynamics, research has shown that EA requires attention to the verbal and nonverbal cues of one's interaction partner (Gesn & Ickes, 1999; Hall & Schmid Mast, 2007; Zaki et al., 2009). Perceivers who are preoccupied with their own frustrations during conflict might have less cognitive ability to pay attention to these cues, resulting in lower EA within the same person. Additionally, individuals with higher need frustration might be less motivated to understand their partner due to not having their own needs met. Moreover, since need frustration is a source of stress (Tindall & Curtis, 2019) that was found to impair EA in women but not men, when experienced at high levels (Crenshaw et al., 2019), this presumed negative link between need frustration and EA might vary by gender, with women's EA potentially being more negatively impacted by their own need frustration than men—altogether suggesting a negative association of need frustration and EA within the same person.

In sum, previous research suggests that need frustration and EA are associated within the same person and between partners, in the context of couple conflict. The following hypotheses will be tested: (a) Need frustration and EA are associated within perceivers during couples' conflict, and (b) need frustration and EA are associated between partners during couples' conflict. Because prior research theoretically supports both positive and negative associations between need frustration and EA, within and between partners, we allowed the data to inform us about the association.

Method

Procedure

Participants

A total of 141 mixed-gender couples participated in the study. The average age was 36.29 years for men (SD = 14.15), ranging from 19 to 76 years, and 34.20 years (SD = 13.70) for women, ranging from 19 to 71 years. On average, couples reported a relationship duration of 11.84 years (SD = 12.02), ranging from 1 to 47 years. A detailed description of the participants' educational level, occupation status, and family situation can be found in Supplemental Table S1.

Recruitment

Inclusion criteria required participants to (a) be in a mixed-gender relationship for at least 1 year, (b) be married or cohabiting for at least 6 months, and (c) have adequate knowledge of the Dutch language.

After the participants' eligibility was established, both partners independently completed an online questionnaire from home. The subsequent observational part of the study included a videotaped conflict interaction task and a video review task similar to those used in previous research (Hinnekens et al., 2016; Verhofstadt et al., 2016).

Conflict Interaction Task

The conflict interaction task took place either at the participants' home (n = 27) or in our lab (n = 114), based on the participants' preference.[1] The lab was equipped with two chairs facing each other and cameras to record the interaction. At-home sessions were recorded in a quiet room with a portable camera.

To facilitate the conflict interaction, participants individually identified a reoccurring source of disagreement in their relationship from a list of common conflict topics (e.g., trust, intimacy, finances). One partner was randomly assigned the initiator role[2] and introduced their chosen conflict topic before the couple discussed it for 11 min. The researcher left the room during the couples' conflict interaction, both at home and in the lab.

Video Review Task

After the conflict interaction task, participants watched their recorded interaction, which automatically stopped every 90 s (seven times). At each stop, they answered questions about their own and their partner's feelings and thoughts during the reviewed video segment, and at two stop points, they answered questions about their need frustration. A detailed description of the conflict and video review task can be found in previous publications (Berlamont et al., 2023).

Measures

Empathic Accuracy

Participants were asked to complete the following four open-ended phrases in regard to the last 10 s of the previous video segment: "I thought," "I felt" and "My partner thought," and "My partner felt" at seven stop points during the video review task. After data collection, groups of four trained coders, independently rated the similarity between actual and inferred thoughts and the actual and inferred feelings on a 3-point scale, resulting in two EA indices at each stop

[1] Additional analyses were conducted to inspect whether the results differed by location. These results can be found in Supplemental Tables S10–S12.

[2] Additional analyses were conducted to inspect whether the results differed based on the partners' conflict role (conflict initiator vs. non-initiator). These results are presented in Supplemental Tables S13–S15.

point. Accuracy was rated on a scale ranging from 0 (different content from the actual thought/feeling) to 1 (similar, but not the same, content as the actual thought/feeling) to 2 (essentially the same content as the actual thought/feeling) (Ickes, 2001).

Interaction-Based Need Frustration

At Time Points 2 and 5 during the video review task, participants rated their level of autonomy, relatedness, and competence frustration using the following three self-construed items, adapted from the Basic Psychological Needs and Satisfaction and Frustration Scale (Chen et al., 2015). (a) "At this moment, I was experiencing a lack of freedom of choice" (autonomy frustration); (b) "At this moment, I was experiencing a lack of relatedness" (relatedness frustration), and (c) "At this moment, I was experiencing a lack of appreciation for my competencies" (competence frustration). All items were answered on a 7-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*completely untrue*) to 7 (*completely true*).

Data Analysis

Due to the weak correlations between EA scores across time points (see Supplemental Table S3), we opted for not averaging EA scores across time points as was done in previous studies (e.g., Verhofstadt et al., 2008). Instead, two separate cross-sectional actor-partner interdependence models (APIM) for need frustration and EA at Time Points 2 and 5 were conducted. This allows for cross-validation of findings and assessment of robustness across different time points of the conflict interaction. Time Points 2 and 5 were selected because both EA and need frustration were measured at these time points.

The normality assumption and presence of possible outliers were inspected, and no deviations were detected. Need frustration scores were averaged across the three items at Time Point 2 (for men $\alpha = .65$ and for women $\alpha = .75$) and across the three items at Time Point 5 (for men $\alpha = .64$ and for women $\alpha = .72$). The four raters' EA scores for feelings and thoughts across all seven time points were sufficiently consistent (intraclass correlation coefficient = .70) to be averaged across raters. Therefore, EA scores for Time Points 2 and 5 were computed by averaging the EA scores for feelings and thoughts at each time point separately. The final EA percentage scores were computed by dividing the total EA scores by the maximum score possible, multiplied by 100.

An APIM was used because it allows to test both actor (i.e., effect of one's own predictor on one's own outcome) and partner effects (i.e., effect of one's own predictor on the partner's outcome) in a single model, while controlling for the interdependence between dyad members' scores (Bolger & Laurenceau, 2013; Kenny et al., 2020). The APIM was fitted using an interactive online application (developed by Stas et al., 2018), which uses structural equation modeling and runs the R package lavaan (Rosseel, 2012) in the background.

A stepwise model building procedure was applied separately for the APIMs at Time Points 2 and 5 to assess whether controlling for (a) baseline need frustration (assessed prior to the conflict interaction), (b) negative emotions during the conflict interaction, (c) relationship satisfaction, or (d) relationship duration improved the fit of the baseline models (see Supplemental Tables S6–S9). Since none of these covariates enhanced the model fit for either time point, the results of the baseline APIMs are reported below. A comparison of model fits, as indicated by the Akaike information criterion, is available in the Supplemental Table S2, along with detailed descriptions of the control variables (pp. 1–2 in the Supplemental Materials).

Directionality of the Effect

In a secondary analysis, we examined the directionality of the hypothesized effects, providing evidence that need frustration influences EA rather than vice versa. For further details, the interested reader is referred to Supplemental Tables S16–S18. Note that these results should be interpreted with caution due to several methodological limitations. Notably, the analyses for each directionality relied on different measurement time points for need frustration and EA, limiting the direct comparability of results. Additionally, the absence of a clear theoretical framework specifying an optimal time lag raises the possibility that the absence of a significant EA → need frustration effect may be due to this relationship unfolding over a different time scale than the observed need frustration → EA link. However, because EA was measured at seven time points and need frustration at only two, comparable analyses across lags were not feasible. Consequently, the decision was made to focus on the cross-sectional analyses as the primary results of this study.

Transparency and Openness

The present study is a secondary analysis of data that were collected in 2014 in the Family Lab in the Department of Experimental-Clinical and Health Psychology of Ghent University, which resulted in previous publications (Berlamont et al., 2023; Hinnekens et al., 2016, 2018; Pirrone et al., 2023). We report how we determined our sample size, all data exclusions, all manipulations, and all measures in the study. The data are available at https://osf.io/xt58w/. This study's design and analysis were not preregistered. No post hoc power analysis was conducted because of existing issues with these analyses (Hoenig & Heisey, 2001). The study was approved by the ethical committee of the Faculty of Psychology and Educational Sciences at Ghent University (REF No. 2014/23).

Results

Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics for the key variables can be found in Table 1.

Distinguishability

Given the sample of mixed-gender couples and previous research that suggests that the hypothesized association between need frustration and EA during conflict might differ by gender, dyad members were treated as distinguishable based on the variable gender.

APIM Results

Detailed results for the APIMs at Time Points 2 and 5 are presented in Table 2. Correlations between need frustration and EA scores across partners for each time point are provided in Supplemental Table S4. Residual nonindependence between partners' EA scores was high, with residual correlations of $r = 0.19$ at Time Point 2 and $r = 0.13$ at Time Point 5. For details on the covariances between dyad members'

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics for Need Frustration and Empathic Accuracy at Time Points 2 and 5

Variable	Partner	*M*	*SD*	Minimum	Maximum	*n*
Time Point 2						
NF	Men	2.083	1.155	1.000	6.000	141
	Women	1.929	1.175	1.000	6.677	141
EA %	Men	20.257	19.277	0.000	93.750	141
	Women	20.213	20.818	0.000	81.250	141
Time Point 5						
NF	Men	2.076	1.081	1.000	5.333	141
	Women	1.974	1.204	1.000	6.000	141
EA %	Men	21.956	20.763	0.000	81.250	141
	Women	21.498	19.938	0.000	81.250	141

Note. The theoretical range of empathic accuracy % is 0 (none of the partner's feelings and *thoughts* were accurately inferred) to 100 (all of the partner's feelings and thoughts were accurately inferred); the theoretical range of need frustration is 1 (completely untrue) to 7 (completely true). NF = need frustration; EA = empathic accuracy; n = sample size.

EA and need frustration scores at Time Points 2 and 5, see Supplemental Table S5.

Actor Effect

At Time Point 2, women's need frustration was marginally negatively associated with their own EA ($p = .053$), with a standardized effect of −0.174 (partial $r = -0.161$). For men, the actor effect of need frustration on their own EA was positive but not significant ($p = .496$), with a standardized effect of 0.003 (partial $r = 0.057$). The difference between the two actor effects of men and women was marginally significant ($p = .070$, 95% confidence interval, CI [−0.33, 8.35]).

At Time Point 5, women's need frustration was marginally negatively associated with their own EA ($p = .073$), with a standardized effect of −0.143 (partial $r = -0.149$). For men, the actor effect was positive but not significant ($p = .178$), with a standardized effect of 0.006 (partial $r = 0.113$). The difference between the two actor effects of men and women was statistically significant ($p = .031$, 95% CI [0.43, 9.1]).

Partner Effect

At Time Point 2, the partner effect of women's need frustration on men's EA was not significant ($p = .868$), with a standardized effect of −0.014 (partial $r = -0.014$). Conversely, the partner effect of men's need frustration on women's EA was positive and significant ($p = .050$), with a standardized effect of 0.180 (partial $r = 0.163$). The difference between the two partner effects for men and women was not statistically significant ($p = .132$, 95% CI [−7.69, 1.01]).

At Time Point 5, the partner effect of women's need frustration on men's EA was not significant ($p = .216$), with a standardized effect of −0.103 (partial $r = -0.104$). The partner effect of men's need frustration on women's EA was negative but not significant ($p = .646$) with a standardized effect of −0.041 (partial $r = -0.039$). The difference between the two partner effects for men and women was not statistically significant ($p = .615$, 95% CI [−5.42, 3.21]).

Discussion

At Time Point 2, the results reveal a significant positive partner effect between men's need frustration and women's EA, suggesting that when men experience need frustration during conflict, women tend to more accurately understand their male partner's thoughts and feelings. This finding supports previous research that showed that EA is influenced by motivation and aligns with the idea that emotions serve an interpersonal communicative function (Keltner & Haidt, 1999; Van Kleef, 2009). During conflict, men's need frustration may serve as a cue that motivates women to increase their efforts to understand their male partner's feelings and thoughts. That this association could not be cross-validated at Time Point 5 could suggest that the link between men's need frustration and women's EA during conflict is dynamic and possibly dependent on the trajectory of the conflict. For example, one might speculate that women's

Table 2
Results of the Actor–Partner Interdependence Models at Time Point 2 and Time Point 5 During the Couple's Conflict Interaction

Effect	Partner	Estimate	*SE*	95% CI *LL*	95% CI *UL*	z-value	*p*	β (*o*)	β (*s*)	*r*
Time Point 2										
Intercept	Women	19.544		11.671	27.418		<.001			
Actor_W		−2.997	1.551	−6.037	0.044	−1.932	.053	−0.174	−0.169	−0.161
$\text{Partner}_{M \to W}$		3.096	1.578	0.004	6.188	1.963	.050	0.180	0.172	0.163
Intercept	Men	18.615		11.191	26.039		<.001			
Actor_M		1.014	1.487	−1.902	3.929	0.681	.496	0.003	0.061	0.057
$\text{Partner}_{W \to M}$		−0.243	1.463	−3.110	2.624	−0.166	.868	−0.014	−0.015	−0.014
Time Point 5										
Intercept	Women	28.026		19.986	36.066		<.001			
Actor_W		−2.544	1.418	−5.322	0.235	−1.794	.073	−0.143	−0.154	−0.149
$\text{Partner}_{M \to W}$		−0.726	1.578	−3.820	2.368	−0.460	.646	−0.041	−0.039	−0.039
Intercept	Men	20.963		12.550	29.376		<.001			
Actor_M		2.222	1.652	−1.015	5.459	1.346	.178	0.006	0.116	0.113
$\text{Partner}_{W \to M}$		−1.834	1.483	−4.741	1.073	−1.236	.216	−0.103	−0.106	−0.104

Note. $N = 141$ mixed-gender couples. p values < .05 are considered significant. *SE* = standard error; CI = confidence interval; *LL* = lower limit; *UL* = upper limit; M = man; W = woman.

initial motivation to engage with their partner's feelings and thoughts decreases over time as the conflict approaches resolution. Future research is needed to examine how different stages of couple conflict and levels of partners' motivation might impact the link between need frustration and EA over the course of a conflict interaction.

The lack of a significant partner effect of women's need frustration on men's EA could be interpreted in line with previous research suggesting that women take on a more active role during couple conflict (Hojjat, 2000). However, although previous research suggests a gender difference, these results should be interpreted with caution, given that no statistically significant difference between the partner effects of men and women was found.

The marginally significant negative actor effect for women at both time points suggests a trend whereby women's need frustration is associated with a reduced ability to understand their male partner's thoughts and feelings during conflict. This trend aligns with previous research indicating that EA requires cognitive resources (Gesn & Ickes, 1999; Hall & Schmid Mast, 2007; Zaki et al., 2009) and that individuals preoccupied with their own distress might have reduced cognitive resources to attend to their partner's cues, potentially leading to lower EA. However, given that the women's actor effect was only marginally significant at both time points, caution is warranted in interpreting these results.

Additionally, the significant difference in actor effects between men and women at Time Point 5 (at Time Point 2, this difference was only marginally significant) could suggest a potential gender-specific difference in need frustration and EA. This finding could be interpreted in line with previous research showing that high levels of stress undermine women's EA but not men's EA (Crenshaw et al., 2019). However, as stress was not measured in course of this study, this interpretation remains speculative.

In summary, women's EA was significantly positively associated with men's need frustration at Time Point 2 but not at Time Point 5. Additionally, women's EA was marginally negatively associated with women's own need frustration at both time points. These findings are partly consistent with previous research and suggest a complex relationship between need frustration and EA during couples' conflict interactions. They also highlight the need for longitudinal studies to (a) explore how different stages of conflict and varying levels of partner motivation and stress affect the link between need frustration and EA and (b) extend the current analyses with a longitudinal APIM with a range of different time lags to provide more robust insights into the causal link and temporal process between need frustration and EA.

Constraints on Generality

The results may have limited generalizability due to the study's convenience sample of primarily well-educated participants in mixed-gender relationships. These demographics may influence EA and need frustration, making our findings applicable primarily to samples with these characteristics.

References

Berlamont, L., Hodges, S., Sels, L., Ceulemans, E., Ickes, W., Hinnekens, C., & Verhofstadt, L. (2023). Motivation and empathic accuracy during conflict interactions in couples: It's complicated! *Motivation and Emotion*, *47*(2), 208–228. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11031-022-09982-x

Bolger, N., & Laurenceau, J.-P. (2013). *Intensive longitudinal methods: An introduction to diary and experience sampling research*. Guilford Press.

Chen, B., Vansteenkiste, M., Beyers, W., Boone, L., Deci, E. L., Van der Kaap-Deeder, J., Duriez, B., Lens, W., Matos, L., Mouratidis, A., Ryan, R. M., Sheldon, K. M., Soenens, B., Van Petegem, S., & Verstuyf, J. (2015). Basic psychological need satisfaction, need frustration, and need strength across four cultures. *Motivation and Emotion*, *39*(2), 216–236. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11031-014-9450-1

Crenshaw, A. O., Leo, K., & Baucom, B. R. W. (2019). The effect of stress on empathic accuracy in romantic couples. *Journal of Family Psychology*, *33*(3), 327–337. https://doi.org/10.1037/fam0000508

Eckland, N. S., Huang, A. B., & Berenbaum, H. (2020). Empathic accuracy: Associations with prosocial behavior and self-insecurity. *Emotion*, *20*(7), 1306–1310. https://doi.org/10.1037/emo0000622

Gesn, P. R., & Ickes, W. (1999). The development of meaning contexts for empathic accuracy: Channel and sequence effects. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, *77*(4), 746–761. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.77.4.746

Hall, J. A., & Schmid Mast, M. (2007). Sources of accuracy in the empathic accuracy paradigm. *Emotion*, *7*(2), 438–446. https://doi.org/10.1037/1528-3542.7.2.438

Hinnekens, C., Loeys, T., De Schryver, M., & Verhofstadt, L. L. (2018). The manageability of empathic (in) accuracy during couples' conflict: Relationship-Protection or self-protection? *Motivation and Emotion*, *42*, 403–418. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11031-018-9689-z

Hinnekens, C., Vanhee, G., De Schryver, M., Ickes, W., & Verhofstadt, L. L. (2016). Empathic accuracy and observed demand behavior in couples. *Frontiers in Psychology*, *7*, Article 1370. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2016.01370

Hoenig, J. M., & Heisey, D. M. (2001). The abuse of power: The pervasive fallacy of power calculations for data analysis. *The American Statistician*, *55*(1), 19–24. https://doi.org/10.1198/000313001300339897

Hojjat, M. (2000). Sex differences and perceptions of conflict in romantic relationships. *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, *17*(4–5), 598–617. https://doi.org/10.1177/0265407500174007

Ickes, W. (1993). Empathic accuracy. *Journal of Personality*, *61*(4), 587–610. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-6494.1993.tb00783.x

Ickes, W. (2001). Measuring empathic accuracy. In J. A. Hall & F. J. Bernieri (Eds.), *Interpersonal sensitivity: Theory and measurement* (pp. 219–241). Lawrence Erlbaum Associates Publishers.

Keltner, D., & Haidt, J. (1999). Social functions of emotions at four levels of analysis. *Cognition and Emotion*, *13*(5), 505–521. https://doi.org/10.1080/026999399379168

Kenny, D. A., Kashy, D. A., & Cook, W. L. (2020). *Dyadic data analysis*. Guilford Press.

Kilpatrick, S. D., Bissonnette, V. L., & Rusbult, C. E. (2002). Empathic accuracy and accommodative behavior among newly married couples. *Personal Relationships*, *9*(4), 369–393. https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-6811.09402

Klein, K. J., & Hodges, S. D. (2001). Gender differences, motivation, and empathic accuracy: When it pays to understand. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, *27*(6), 720–730. https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167201276007

Lazarus, G., Bar-Kalifa, E., & Rafaeli, E. (2018). Accurate where it counts: Empathic accuracy on conflict and no-conflict days. *Emotion*, *18*(2), 212–228. https://doi.org/10.1037/emo0000325

Patrick, H., Knee, C. R., Canevello, A., & Lonsbary, C. (2007). The role of need fulfillment in relationship functioning and well-being: A self-determination theory perspective. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, *92*(3), 434–457. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.92.3.434

Pirrone, D., Sels, L., & Verhofstadt, L. (2023). Relational needs frustration: An observational study on the role of negative (dis)engaging emotions. *Frontiers in Psychology*, *14*, Article 1232125. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2023.1232125

Rosseel, Y. (2012). lavaan: An R package for structural equation modeling. *Journal of Statistical Software*, *48*(2), 1–36. https://doi.org/10.18637/jss.v048.i02

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation, social development, and well-being. *American Psychologist*, *55*(1), 68–78. https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68

Sened, H., Lavidor, M., Lazarus, G., Bar-Kalifa, E., Rafaeli, E., & Ickes, W. (2017). Empathic accuracy and relationship satisfaction: A meta-analytic review. *Journal of Family Psychology*, *31*(6), 742–752. https://doi.org/10.1037/fam0000320

Stas, L., Kenny, D. A., Mayer, A., & Loeys, T. (2018). Giving dyadic data analysis away: A user-friendly app for actor–partner interdependence models. *Personal Relationships*, *25*(1), 103–119. https://doi.org/10.1111/pere.12230

Tindall, I. K., & Curtis, G. J. (2019). Validation of the measurement of need frustration. *Frontiers in Psychology*, *10*, Article 1742. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.01742

Van Kleef, G. A. (2009). How emotions regulate social life: The emotions as social information (EASI) model. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, *18*(3), 184–188. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-8721.2009.01633.x

Vanhee, G., Lemmens, G., & Verhofstadt, L. L. (2016). Relationship satisfaction: High need satisfaction or low need frustration? *Social Behavior and Personality: An International Journal*, *44*, 923–930. https://doi.org/10.2224/sbp.2016.44.6.923

Vanhee, G., Lemmens, G. M. D., Stas, L., Loeys, T., & Verhofstadt, L. L. (2018). Why are couples fighting? A need frustration perspective on relationship conflict and dissatisfaction. *Journal of Family Therapy*, *40*(S1), S4–S23. https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-6427.12126

Verhofstadt, L. L., Buysse, A., Ickes, W., Davis, M., & Devoldre, I. (2008). Support provision in marriage: The role of emotional similarity and empathic accuracy. *Emotion*, *8*(6), 792–802. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0013976

Verhofstadt, L. L., Devoldre, I., Buysse, A., Stevens, M., Hinnekens, C., Ickes, W., & Davis, M. (2016). The role of cognitive and affective empathy in spouses' support interactions: An observational study. *PLOS ONE*, *11*(2), Article e0149944. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0149944

Zaki, J., Bolger, N., & Ochsner, K. (2009). Unpacking the informational bases of empathic accuracy. *Emotion*, *9*(4), 478–487. https://doi.org/10.1037/a0016551

Received March 19, 2024
Revision received February 13, 2025
Accepted April 21, 2025 ■